on trains.' That would have been wonderful material for my programme, but unfortunately, the husband had just got off the train.

There have been my encounters with the railway staff too. A favourite story, which I have told more than once, concerns my suggesting to a travelling ticket examiner that it was a bit hard having to pay a superfast surcharge to crawl up the steep climb from Chandigarh to Kalka. The outraged official replied, 'This *is* a superfast train. It is only going slow.'

On another occasion, when I enquired why my train had stopped, I was told, 'line punctured', which, I discovered, meant there was a cracked rail.

The poet Robert Browning wrote of 'the story always old and always new'. I have found stories so effective in journalism because, although they tell of the past, they never lose their freshness. They instruct; for instance, the construction of the line through the Bolan Pass illustrates the ingenuity of Victorian engineers, while the anecdote of the Pathan tribesmen provides a telling example of the opposition the railway builders faced. Stories like my encounters with passengers and railway staff entertain, and so, are an important element in keeping listeners', viewers' and readers' attention.

As historian Rajendra B. Aklekar is a storyteller too, and a railway devotee, he has chosen to tell stories, or tales, to narrate the history of Indian Railways from the 1830s to today. His stories instruct and entertain, bringing the past of the Indian Railways alive in the present. They will entertain as well as instruct, thereby encouraging Indians to be proud of their railways' past and to ensure that those railways play a crucial role in the future.

Mark Tully